

MOBILE INTERNET FOR THE MASSES

July Systems' Mi Channels programme takes the mobile Internet to a mass user base with free content, rich user experience, familiar media brands and regional content

■ SRABANI SEN

In a bid to target the mass user base, including India's non-metro and regional mobile users, July Systems, a leading mobile media company, has come up with an innovative programme that not only offers mobile Internet content for free but also easy access to content and uncomplicated navigation for news, pictures and videos on the mobile. Furthermore, it offers regional content on mobile phones. The programme has been constructed over the last ten years by the July Systems team. It is a Java-based platform, which has various components, with different interfaces supporting advertisers, publishers, etc.

"In partnership with Zoom TV for its Mi Channels mobile Internet programme, July Systems aspires to capture the Indian mass market and make mobile Internet easily accessible," states Yudhishter Gopalkrishna,

director, strategic alliances and business development, July Systems. July Systems is a mobile Internet pioneer that powers channels for entertainment, sports, sports leagues and business news in India and the US.

"It is a mass market product and depending on the type of handset one has, the programme can leverage on the handset capabilities to offer an optimised experience," adds Gopalkrishna.

NDTV Convergence has also tied up with July Systems for a free SMS service, MiSMS, which will allow users to receive news, videos, stocks and cricket scores hosted on NDTV Active through SMS.

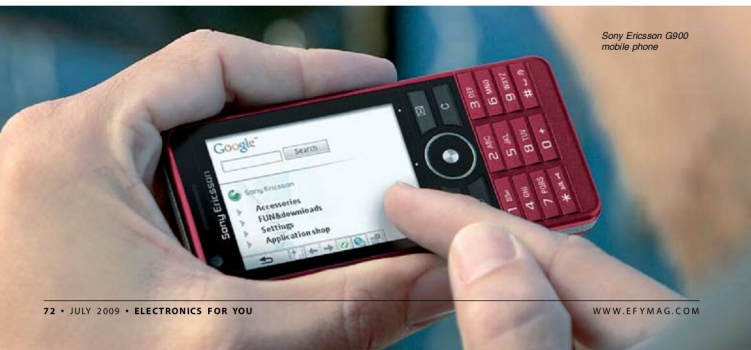
"With this co-branded programme, we're finally taking mobile Internet to a vast Indian audience, who so far weren't even properly acquainted with the Web," says Gopalkrishna. "To brands, Mi Channels provides the opportunity to court India's regional

audiences, in a language they're familiar with. Indian advertisers can now efficiently target consumers across geographies through this tool. Soon, we'll be adding other partners from the business, sports, news and entertainment arenas to this programme," elaborates Gopalkrishna.

According to a study, the usage of new mobile phone applications, including mobile Internet browsing, multimedia features, games and other new applications, has been escalating among mobile users and has already reached 40 per cent of the total face time. Potential usage of new applications could be even higher, says the study.

How to avail

Mi Channels can be availed by any mobile user through general packet radio service (GPRS), Wi-Fi, iTunes or carrier decks. "Presently, mobile users in India pay for content and value-added



Sony Ericsson G900 mobile phone